

How Radical is Anger?

The biggest Muslim complaint today is that they are not integrated enough into the India Rising story, a point proven by the Rajinder Sachar Report

M.J. AKBAR

Indian Muslims wear their anger in their eyes but does that make them radical in the sense of seeking to subvert the Indian nation-state? The much-lauded Deoband *fatwa* against terrorism had a less-publicised sting in its tail. It noted that Indian Muslims had legitimate reasons for their anger, implying discrimination and injustice. The seeming paradox accurately reflects the dilemma and the opportunity. Injustice craves redressal but is not yet fuel for insurrection.

The "radicalisation" of Islam is quite a different story from the contemporary angst of Muslims, even when there is a visual overlap: the black mark that neo-zealots sometimes adopt to indicate excessive prayer. Those who confuse religiosity with religion are easily tempted towards posturing. The "radicalisation" of Islam was a

19th-century phenomenon that rocked the British Empire with a jihad that lasted more than half a century and then petered out to discover a puritan resting place in the Tablighi Jamaat.

The history of the anger of Indian Muslims is marked by three phases: the Khilafat movement between 1912 (sparked by the Balkan offensive against Turkey) and 1922 (when it was aborted by Mahatma Gandhi); the Pakistan movement (1940 to 1947) and now the discontent of the Indian Muslims.

The Khilafat rage was radical, non-violent and inclusive, because it sought to destroy the British Empire with the support of fellow Indians, and therefore accepted the leadership and non-violence of Gandhi. The Pakistan movement was radical (as it wanted to divide India), violent, exclusive and even mildly racist because its leadership was consumed by false notions of superiority.

Today's anger is radically different from the 1940s, for Indian Muslims have understood that they were wrong in 1947 and Maulana Azad was right. It was not an answer to their subcontinental existential questions—whatever it might have meant to pockets in the west and east.

In the '40s, Muslims could not be separatist

enough. Today they are not integrated enough into the success story that is India Rising. Rajinder Sachar's inquiry into their condition was historic, for it confirmed every suspicion they nurtured of economic apartheid. Its publication marked the turning point of their political emotions in Bengal, where the clay image of secularism created by the Marxists fell apart under the scrutiny of facts.

Muslims are asking the Congress more than one question. Why do other communities, like the backward castes, get reservations and why do Muslims only get enquiry commissions? What is left to inquire when poverty is etched on the hunger lines of their stomachs? The quiet burial of the Sachar Report by the Congress has become further confirmation of betrayal. They have watched Waqf property being looted by ministers in Congress governments in Maharashtra and Andhra Pradesh, their young tortured in Hyderabad, and the Sri Krishna Commission Report ignored. Is anger also to be denied to them?

Muslim anger is analogous to the bitterness that spawned the Naxalite movement. They would have joined the Naxalites in greater numbers but atheism keeps Marx away from Muslims. Instead, a few who seek the gun search for inspiration from a Salafist Osama bin Laden rather than Lenin or Mao.

There is a further reason for the disproportionate decibel levels that emanate from the destructive fringe. Independent India has not produced a single Muslim leader of stature, charisma and self respect that the wider community can absorb. There have been leaders with one or the other, but not all three. Indian Muslims are searching for a leader who can build equity through empowerment. Will the moment produce the man? The answer is depressing, for the moment. But the leaderless community has found alternative routes towards the future. It is investing heavily in the classroom. The hum of learning can never compete with the roar of explosives, but we should not confuse silence with inactivity.

Indian Muslims have become masters of another silent weapon—the ballot. In the last general elections, they sought out the enemy. In the next, they will seek out the hypocrites.

The writer is a senior journalist and author



SAURABH SINGH